



workshop

need to do is add an entry for your city. Go to Check the Weather link menu and then to Settings. Choose to change the Area code and type in the city followed by a comma, then India. If weather updates for your town or city are available, the weather window will show them. Change the Region in the same settings menu to UK. This will display temperatures in Celcius instead of Fahrenheit. Click on Refresh to update the cities you've added to the list.



The Weather menu displays current for the specified cities

Controlling using an Xbox controller

If you already have an Xbox 360 or an Xbox 360 controller, it's a good idea to use it with the HTPC. For one, the cable is long enough for you to sit at a comfortable distance and control the PC without the need of a keyboard and mouse. We suggest using free software called



Using Xpadder, you can set a game controller to control XBMC

Xpadder (www.xpadder.com).

Xpadder lets you bind keyboard keys to the controller. XBMC is controlled by a set of some 8 to 10 keys in all. The same keys can be bound using



DisplayPort like HDMI is a display connectivity standard but is royalty-free

this software.

First, download and install the Windows drivers for the X360 controller and then install Xpadder. Xpadder will detect your controller. First, start the controller setup by clicking the controller icon on the left top of the software. Click New. Here, enable all the buttons and triggers you want to use for XBMC. Once that's done, you can click on each of the buttons shown in the display and a virtual keyboard will be displayed. You can click on each of the keys to bind that button to the keyboard. You will also see a mouse on this virtual keyboard. You can even set the buttons and joysticks on the controller to function as a mouse.

XBMC Scripts and Plugins

Being an open-source software package, scripts and add-ons are available for XBMC. One of the plugins that comes with the program is the Apple Trailers script. This plugin downloads Apple Trailers videos for you from its site without



Trailers from Apple's site can be viewed directly within XBMC

having to open a browser. The site is updated pretty often and it's good fun to be able to view trailers this easily.

Plugins can be installed by simply unzipping the archive to your Plugins folder in the installed XBMC folder. To access the plugin, go to the Use your Programs menu and to the Programs Plugins folder. XBMC Zone (www.xbmczone.com) and <http://tinyurl.com/d25nrz> are good places to start looking for plugins of interest. It's not hard to find scripts and plugins for all kinds of needs starting from viewing RSS feeds from Google Reader in XBMC to viewing videos in full-screen from Youtube. ■

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Media Portal

www.team-mediaportal.com

Media Portal is geared more towards those who have their TV and radio broadcasts being processed through the computer. The general look and feel of the software isn't very nice and the performance seems to be slightly sluggish as well. One of the interesting features is the configuration



tool. It allows users to completely configure the system outside of its HTPC interface like any other Windows application. Support and configuration for the hardware remotes is also done within the software. Installation of plugins is also simple. Media Portal is versatile with great potential but requires users to sit and tweak and configure bits of the software themselves.

Boxee

www.boxee.tv

Boxee is somewhat similar to XBMC and that's because it's a branch of XBMC like Media Portal. It's geared more towards social network-

ing and some of interesting features is the ability to retrieve and view content off the internet, all without having to go through the hurdles of installing and setting up plugins to do that for you.

Vista Media Center

www.microsoft.com

Vista comes with a built-in media centre application and if you own Vista, you most likely have an HTPC frontend program built-in. Although it might not support all the formats you want to use, it's depends highly on the internet for media and information on sports matches and such like. It also has the ability to record TV programs, access internet TV channels and even burn disks. Unfortunately, a lot of the online content isn't available for India so you're left with

somewhat handi-capped software. If you don't want to go through the hassle of downloading and installing a program and use conventional media formats or play movies off your DVD drive, then Vista Media Center should be sufficient for your needs.

